

cause fewer houses may sell, and those that do sell will often differ greatly in size and amenities.

Next, the appraiser compares your house's features (age, condition, number of bedrooms, etc.) to the comps, and calculates an adjusted sales price for each of the comps; from that information, he/she can develop a market value.

Appraisers may also consider the replacement cost of the home or use the income approach: estimated monthly rent $\times$ GRM (gross rent multiplier) to develop market values.

ONLINE HOME-VALUATION SITES

Sites such as Zillow.com, Eppraisal.com, and RealEstateABC.com aggregate public records and, with the help of mapping technology, develop a home value (or rather, a range of values) based on recent sale prices of nearby homes (but not necessarily ones that are comparable to yours). However, Real Estate ABC has an interactive feature. In my case, I could keep the comps that were in my neighborhood of single-family homes and de-select the large homes with significant acreage and the condos less than a mile away. This approach, though simplified, is most similar to methods used in a real appraisal.

APPRAISER BULLYING

When I was in the market for the house I own now, in the 1990s, a licensed real estate agent explained the appraisal process to me like this: The appraiser starts figuring the value of the house but stops when he/she gets to the contract (sales) price. I found her comments disturbing; technically, she was wrong, but she did reveal to me some gaps in the real estate sales-lending system. According to the Appraisal Standards Board, potential clients have made requests that are contrary to industry standards for real estate appraisal, such as:

"We need comps for (property description) that will support a loan of \$_____; can you provide them?"

"Approximate (or minimum) value needed: _____."

"If this property will not appraise for at least _____, stop and call us immediately."

Making the appraisal = the sales price or loan amount is not a good idea, as the State of New York and First American have confirmed.

In regard to the pending nightmare awhile back, my husband and I found ourselves selling a house that we had owned for less than six months due to a corporate relocation; we had bought the house at a mod-